

Response 1: Redefining the 'National Family': An Analysis of Gender Roles and Narrative Complexity in Friends

After the week 5 class of this course and watching the series *Friends*, I know the series became a cultural phenomenon because it shows the struggles of early adulthood in a way that is eminently relatable to the younger generation, mostly young-adults in their 20s, such as friendship, love,... and its humour elements. These elements are further clarified in Season 9, Episode 20 - *The One with the Soap Opera Party* which was shown in the class. In this reflection, I will write about my reflection about this episode along with the construction of a "national family" (Morley, 2000).

The One with the Soap Opera Party adheres to traditional sitcom conventions while subtly subverting them. The episode's multi-camera setup and laugh track, hallmarks of classic sitcoms, create a sense of familiarity for viewers. In the scene where Chandler confronts Monica about Gavin, the multi-camera setup captures both characters' reactions simultaneously. The laugh track highlights key comedic moments, like Chandler's sarcastic comments and Monica's exasperated responses. This familiar format creates a sense of live performance and guides viewers' emotional responses that this scene is humorous, enhancing the overall comedic effect. However, the show's ensemble cast structure allows for more complex narrative weaving than traditional sitcoms, with multiple storylines intersecting throughout the episode. We see three main storylines (Joey's secret soap opera party, Chandler's jealousy over Monica's coworker, and Rachel's romantic re-exmisadventures) – show the ability to balance multiple character arcs within a 22-minute format. Although this episode is not a perfect example for quality TV, but this complexity of the narrative in the episode makes me remember the discussion of Schlütz's (2016) about the complex serial narratives in contemporary quality TV, which primarily focuses on drama series. *Friends* shows that sitcoms may remain widely popular while achieving a level of narrative sophistication usually associated with more "serious" genres. The show's ongoing popularity can be attributed to its

ability to deftly weave together various storylines within a short structure, thereby challenging conventional concepts of sitcom storytelling.

As I read Morley's concept of the "national family" in the course reading, I found that television plays an important role in reflecting and reinforcing traditional gender norms in society. For example, television will depict men in positions of authority, as breadwinners or in roles that emphasize physical strength and assertiveness. In contrast, women are often portrayed in nurturing roles, managing the household or in occupations traditionally associated with femininity. Through repeated exposure to these depictions, television contributes to the maintenance and perpetuation of these gender norms, shaping viewers' understanding of what constitutes "appropriate" behavior for men and women in a national context. According to Morley, the representation of traditional gender roles in television programs serves to reinforce existing social structures and expectations, thereby contributing to the construction and maintenance of a common national identity or family. In this episode of *Friends*, I found that the episode challenged Morley's notion of gender roles and definitions. This episode makes me focus on contemporary social issues, particularly regarding gender roles and relationships while watching it. I was impressed by the scene about Joey's attempt to keep his rooftop party secret from his friends, only to have it discovered by Rachel and Phoebe, which plays with stereotypes about male bonding and exclusivity. When the women stumble upon the party, Joey's embarrassed reaction highlights the dated notion of gender-segregated socialising. This scenario is further complicated when Rachel and Phoebe decide to crash the party. Their presence disrupts the male-dominated space, challenging traditional gender dynamics. For instance, when Rachel confidently approaches soap opera star Kyle Lowder, she subverts the expectation that women should be passive in romantic pursuits. This moment reflects changing attitudes towards gender roles in dating and social interactions. Meanwhile, Chandler's secret about Monica's attractive coworker, Gavin, addresses themes of trust and jealousy in modern relationships. His comical attempts to assert his masculinity, such as trying to open a jar Monica struggled with, highlights the insecurities men may face in egalitarian relationships where women have successful careers. I like the way this episode breaks stereotypes about man's dominance and women's dependence/passivity. Thus, while Morley's concept of the "national family" posits television as a reinforcer of traditional gender norms,

this episode demonstrates how television can also serve as a platform for challenging and redefining these norms, reflecting evolving societal attitudes towards gender roles and relationships.

Morley's (2000) concept of television's role in creating a "national family" is both challenged and reinvented by *Friends*. Unlike traditional family sitcoms, *Friends* presents a group of young adults who create their own family unit, based on friendship rather than blood ties. This chosen family dynamic subverts conventional representations of the American family on television. The characters' diverse relationship statuses - single, divorced, in committed relationships, or navigating complex romantic situations - reflect a more modern, fluid concept of family. Moreover, their living arrangements, with apartments serving as communal spaces, further challenge traditional domestic settings. Despite this non-conformity, *Friends* still contributes to a sense of national identity by presenting a shared experience of navigating early adulthood in urban America. This redefining of the "national family" offered a more inclusive and contemporary vision of American life that acknowledged changing social dynamics while still fostering a sense of collective identity.

After reflecting on this process along with Morley's "National Family" concept, I realised that this episode of *Friends* both aligned with and challenged that concept. This episode helped me understand more about cultural impact, blending traditional sitcom elements with complex narratives and reflecting American social dynamics. The episode encapsulates *Friends* role in Television history, demonstrating the evolution of sitcoms, the construction of national identity through media, and changing viewing habits. The series' continued popularity underscores television's power to create shared cultural experiences amid the medium's ongoing transformation in the post-broadcast era.

Wordcount: 965 words

1. Schlütz, D.M. 2016, "Contemporary Quality TV: The Entertainment Experience of Complex Serial Narratives", *Annals of the International Communication Association*, vol.40(1), pp.95-124

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3. Tay, J. and Turner, G. (2009). *Television studies after TV: understanding television in the post-broadcast era*, Routledge, London.
4. Ain C (2020) 'Friends', the Cultural Phenomenon, accessed 28 September 2024.
<https://www.seisen.com/student-life/seisen-post/features/~board/seisen-post/post/friends-the-cultural-phenomenon>

Response 2: What Does 'TV' Mean for Me in My Life?

After completing this course, I realised that television has moved from a fixed, scheduled medium to a fluid, on-demand experience. This shift, in my opinion, has an enormous impact on my television usage and what it means for me, particularly as an international student adapting to life in Australia. This reflection will write about how my television viewing habits have not only changed but also become instrumental in my cultural integration.

Moving to Australia, my viewing habits have changed significantly with SVOD services like Netflix playing a key role. I watched television on every Monday and Thursday night- the time that me and my friends are free, we gather at my house to watch Netflix by using a large computer screen. This exemplifies the concept of post-broadcast television, where viewers are no longer bound by traditional broadcasting schedules (Johnson, 2019). The scene we gathered around the screen portrayed the concept of television as an "electronic hearth" (Tichi, 1991), creating a sense of family and belonging in a foreign land. Moreover, as I see in the course readings, our favour with Netflix illustrated its dominance in the Australian market with an estimated 12 million viewers per month (Roy Morgan, 2022, as cited in Scarlata et al., 2022).

We rarely watch broadcast television as its can be replaced by SVOD where we can watch program at anytime, with this use I can understand that SVOD services changed Australian television, undermining the long-established dominance of free-to-air networks and reviving the pay-TV business model (Scarlata, A et al 2022). Our Monday and Thursday Netflix sessions often featured *Emily in Paris*. We found ourselves comparing Emily's faux pas in Paris to my initial misconceptions about Australian culture. For instance, Emily's overly enthusiastic work style contrasting with the French approach led us to discuss differences between Vietnamese, Australian, and American workplace cultures.

When reflecting on this experience, even though me and my friends don't usually binge-watch shows but our regular gathering to watch Netflix bring us closer. It's

pretty cool how we use this SVOD service not just for entertainment, but also as a way to make friends and feel more at home in a new place.

My engagement with Broadcaster Video-on-Demand (BVOD) services, such as ABC iview, 9Now service has helped me acclimate to Australian culture and immerse myself in local content. ABC iview has become my favorite platform for catching up on popular Australian shows just by using my laptop at home in the evening. My recent series is *Return to Paradise*, which taught me about Australia's complex relationship with its Pacific neighbors. The show's portrayal of a detective returning to solve mysteries in the Pacific islands highlighted Australia's historical and contemporary ties to the region, something I hadn't fully appreciated before. This expanded my understanding of Australia's role in the Asia-Pacific beyond what I'd learned in formal settings.

9Now has introduced me to Australian reality TV, particularly *Married at First Sight*. Although it is really new and strange to me, I find this shows me more about the relationships in Australia especially in personality and commitment to social norms. The show's emphasis on open communication and the experts' focus on compatibility factors helped me understand the value placed on emotional intelligence and self-awareness in Australian relationships. This contrasts with the more family-oriented matchmaking processes mainly based on parents' opinions which I was familiar with in Vietnam. I often watch it with my Australian classmates, which has sparked numerous discussions about cultural differences and similarities.

This shift in my viewing habits reflects broader trends in the Australian media landscape. As Scarlata and Lobato (2023) note, BVOD services play a significant role in the Australian television ecosystem, offering a mix of catch-up TV and original content. My experience aligns with their observation that these platforms are becoming increasingly important for content discovery and cultural engagement.

Using BVODs has provided me with common ground for discussions with local friends and helped me better understanding cultural references and jokes. This aligns with Turner's (2018) description of television's role in shaping national identity and cultural understanding. BVOD services have transformed my television viewing

habits from being a passive consumer of familiar Asian content to an active explorer of Australian culture. This change has not only enhanced my understanding of Australian society but also facilitated my social integration. As Lobato, Scarlata, and Schivinski (2023) discuss in their research on smart TVs and local content prominence, the accessibility of local content through these platforms is crucial for cultural integration. My experience exemplifies how BVOD services can serve as a bridge for international students to connect with and understand their host culture.

In conclusion, the meaning of television in my life has transformed from mere entertainment to a multifaceted cultural tool. Television to me is social bonding, a pathway to cultural understanding, and personal growth. The shift from traditional broadcast to SVOD and BVOD services has not only changed how I consume content but has fundamentally altered my relationship with television and its role in my life.

Wordcount: 836 words

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